

Political, social and economic context

At home in Macedon

Alexander and Philip, despite growing pressure from Olympias, were close. This changed with Philip's decision to marry a new wife, the niece of the Macedonian general, Attalus, in 337BC. At the wedding feast an argument erupted when Attalus questioned the right of Alexander to be the Macedonian king as his mother was from Epirus.

Philip and Alexander argued and Alexander left Macedonia with Olympias to live in Epirus. Months later Philip and Alexander made up, but Philip still exiled many of Alexander's friends.

In 336BC, Philip was assassinated. Alexander, with the support of Antipater and Parmenio, Philip's two most experienced and trusted generals, was proclaimed king and accepted by the Macedonian army. Alexander quickly punished those found guilty of the conspiracy against his father and removed rivals to the throne. Attalus was

convicted and executed for treason. Olympias supposedly had Philip's new wife and baby son roasted over a fire while Alexander was away from Macedon (Pausanias 8.7). Alexander was angry with Olympias about this incident when he returned. Other rivals like Amyntas, the son of the king before Philip, and two brothers from the house of Lyncestis were also killed.

Trouble in Greece

Traditionally, the death of a king was a good time for subject peoples to try to gain their freedom. Alexander's first job was to re-establish political control over the Greek states. To stop unrest in Greece he marched his army southward. Alexander was offered the position of archon of Thessaly and, as he marched further south he was quickly accepted as Strategos Autokrator (commander-in-chief) of the forces of the League of Corinth.

Troubles to the north and west

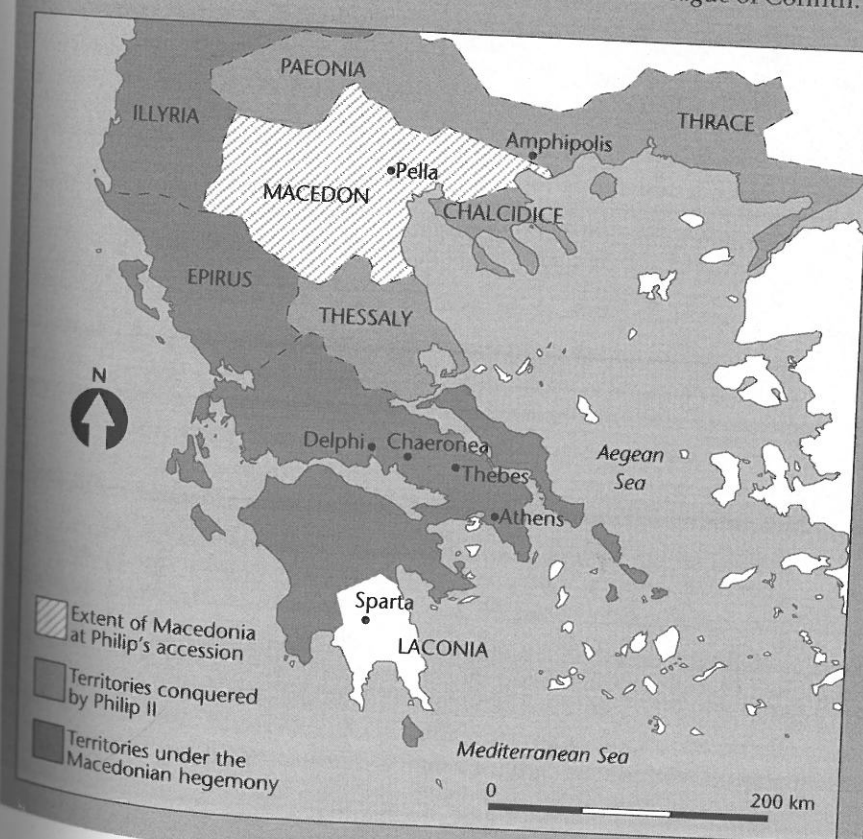
Meanwhile the Thracian tribes under Macedonian control were uneasy. Alexander marched north in 335BC and conducted his first independent campaign. He defeated the Triballi and Getae, who then accepted his overlordship. In Macedonia trouble arose with another invasion by the Illyrians, but Alexander and his army reached Pellum and inflicted a decisive defeat on Cleitus, the Illyrian king.

More trouble to the south

While Alexander was in the north a rumour reached Athens and Thebes that he had supposedly died. The Macedonian garrison was blockaded in the Cadmea at Thebes, and Athens, Aetolia and several Peloponnesian states prepared to join the rebellion. Alexander rapidly marched to Thebes and defeated the Thebans. Their city was destroyed and its inhabitants sold into slavery. The other Greek states, led by Athens, quickly reaccepted Alexander's position as the leader of the League of Corinth. With peace and the Macedonian hegemony over Greece restored, Alexander began his plans for an expedition against the Persian Empire.

His speed and the threat of a Macedonian army had, for the moment, made the Greek states think twice about causing problems.

- Construct a chart. In one column list the problems that Alexander faced on becoming the king of Macedon. In another column list what he did to solve each of them.



The Balkan peninsula at the time of Philip's death